

The flagship curse

ONE OF THE PRIVILEGES of working at Digit is that you get to play with the best that technology can offer. We get it all, from the latest graphics cards and processors to near enterprise grade wireless routers that make you want to buy a rocket launcher for the sole purpose of blowing your existing router to smithereens. It's this very privilege that gives us a better perspective into technological aspects in comparison with someone who only gets to read about them. We read, we play, we test, we dissect and sometimes, we even break gadgets in our quest to satiate our curiosity. However, there is a downside to being in this wonderland that most of us slowly realise as time passes.

Stepping down to the mid-range or entry-level product range is a crushing feeling. Not to mention, the desire to match our work rigs often takes a toll on our pockets. For example, my work rig is an Intel Core i7-4790K coupled with an NVIDIA GTX 980 Ti. Our test rigs have the best Intel and AMD processors with more cores than needed. The SSDs that we run our benchmarks are the fastest consumer grade (or nearly enterprise grade) that money can buy. Now, if we are to move away from PCs, then we get to ride in some of the most luxurious vehicles built by man all the while listening to music on ridiculously expensive, and equally impressive, audio gear. Tearing ourselves away from all of that every day as we head back home is a feat that's nearly worthy of the Zero1 Awards. Since most of us don't have deep pockets or weren't born with a silver spoon, replicating the same hardware experience at home isn't possible. In my case, I'm running a Core i7-3770K with a GTX 970. In the world of incremental updates that we live in, this is pretty damn close to my primary work rig. If I were to use the main Digit Test Rig more often, I'd simply want to stay away from my home PC. And that goes for any hardware I own.

Despite knowing all the pitfalls of switching from enthusiast grade to mid-range hardware, I decided it was high time for me to chuck my old Moto X 2014. It's a 3-year old flagship that has served me quite well and for a change (and to not cause my wallet to cower in fear) I decided to go in for a mid-range phone. Even with

that, I had conditions. Stock UI was preferred, hardware buttons were a necessity, an audio jack was mandatory, and the SoC couldn't be a far cry from the Snapdragon 801 that I was used to. The choices are absolutely disappointing, and not one of them turned out to be in the ₹13-18K price bracket. That is, until the Xiaomi Mi A1 turned up. Stock Android? Check. Hardware buttons? Check. Audio jack? Check. SoC? SD625, not bad. The sales came around and I got my new phone, a supposed upgrade. Or so I thought.

Even in comparison to a three-year old flagship, the Mi A1 still feels unresponsive. I thought of this over and over again as I held the two phones side by side while replicating the same actions over and over again. Perhaps, it was a bias brought out by my understanding of CPUs or perhaps I was developing buyer's remorse or perhaps I was just not ready to let go of my Moto X 2014. With the Moto X 2014, normal and voluminous actions like moving around the UI, browsing, manipulating text and images between apps, etc. was quick and snappy. It was just the mind-numbingly unoptimised apps such as Facebook and Uber, to name a few, that felt jarring. So most of my time on the Moto X felt just fine except for a few moments in the day. On the other hand, the Mi A1 does the opposite. Its single threaded performance is lower than the SD801 which makes the daily mundane tasks feel slightly sluggish but the high resource demanding apps run really great. (Note: High resource demand = poorly coded)

The teensy doubt in my mind over the Mi A1 has now turned into a full-blown case of buyer's remorse. The phone as a whole might be a great machine for anyone who hasn't used a phone with a better SoC but for folks such as yours truly, who spend hours pouring over benchmark results and trying to spot glitches in the UI, these minor things just vividly stand out. So I'm at that juncture where I have to decide, if I should sell off my new purchase and move back to the Moto X till I find an affordable SD835 device or if I should forcefully condition myself to live with these little irritations till I start subconsciously ignoring them. What would you do if you were in my shoes? 



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